of the White House's intentions, they recoiled at the suggestion. The President only met the Joint Chiefs once during the crisis, on Friday, 19 October. General Curtis LeMay told him to his face: 'This blockade and political action, I see leading into war. I don't see any other solution for it. It will lead right into war. This is almost as bad as the appeasement at Munich.'[11]

The idea of a naval blockade as a separate option emerged from the debates among Kennedy's advisers. On 16 October, however, the emphasis was very much on military choices. No one in the White House questioned the need to remove the missiles. Nor did anyone challenge the view that force might be necessary to do so (though Bundy was keen to ensure that a political approach had not been ruled out). McNamara did question whether the missiles changed the military balance. Asked by Bundy about the strategic impact of the MRBMs in Cuba, he replied, 'Mac, I asked the Chiefs that this afternoon [16 October], in effect. They said: "Substantially." My own personal view is: Not at all.'[12] Most members of ExComm agreed with him. More bluntly – though notably when the President had left the room (but with the tape machine running) – the Defense Secretary declared, 'I'll be quite frank. I don't think there is a military problem there … This is a domestic political problem.'[13] The assessment provides grist to the mill of Kennedy's critics, who accused him of taking the world to the brink of nuclear war for domestic political gain. In 1988 Bundy expressed a more subtle connection between the President and the American people:

> What forced his hand in the first place was that the United States government, both through him and through the Congress, had promised the American people [to keep Soviet missiles out of Cuba] … It is his understanding of the consequences of a failure to honor this commitment to his countrymen that explains the firmness of Kennedy's rejection of all courses that did not give promise of getting the missiles out.[14]

Early critics of Kennedy's motives have been joined by recent writers who have condemned the President's willingness to subordinate national security